Biologically, humans are divided into males and females. A male *Homo sapiens* has one X chromosome and one Y chromosome; a female *Homo sapiens* has two Xs. But ‘man’ and ‘woman’ name social, not biological, categories. While in the great majority of cases in most human societies men are males and women are females, the social terms carry a lot of baggage that has only a tenuous, if any, relationship to the biological terms. A man is not a Sapiens with particular biological qualities such as XY chromosomes, testicles and lots of testosterone. Rather, he fits into a particular slot in his society’s imagined human order. His culture’s myths assign him particular masculine roles (like engaging in politics), rights (like voting) and duties (like military service). Likewise, a woman is not a Sapiens with two X chromosomes, a womb and plenty of oestrogen. Rather, she is a female member of an imagined human order. The myths of her society assign her unique feminine roles (raising children), rights (protection against violence) and duties (obedience to her husband). Since myths, rather than biology, define the roles, rights and duties of men and women, the meaning of ‘manhood’ and ‘womanhood’ have varied immensely from one society to another.

A female = a biological category		**A woman = a cultural category**	
Ancient Athens	**Modern Athens**	**Ancient Athens**	**Modern Athens**
XX chromosomes	XX chromosomes	Can’t vote	Can vote
Womb	Womb	Can’t be a judge	Can be a judge
Ovaries	Ovaries	Can’t hold government office	Can hold government office
Little testosterone	Little testosterone	Can’t decide for herself who to marry	Can decide for herself who to marry
Much oestrogen	Much oestrogen	Typically illiterate	Typically literate
Can produce milk	Can produce milk	Legally owned by father or	Legally independent